Tool choice

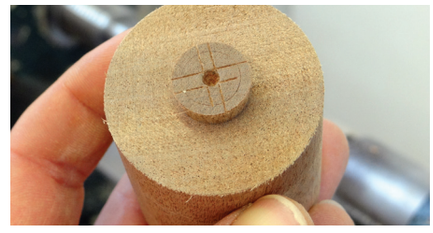
The item that you have been working on is nearly finished: the shape is good, the finish is good, it is sanded smooth. Now your work just needs parting from the waste and it will be ready to apply your finish of choice. Which tool should you use to make that final parting cut? As turners, we have various gouges, chisels and parting tools to choose from and it would seem obvious to pick up a parting tool: surely it does as it says? Actually, of your tool selection, this tool is probably the least favourable option. Of course it will part off the work, but the cutting action of a parting tool is harsh on end grain compared to other cutting tools and will almost certainly leave a torn surface.

Parting tool in action

SO WHY IS IT CALLED A PARTING TOOL IF IT'S NO USE FOR THIS JOB?

I'm not 100% certain of the answer here, but it may be because of a link to metal turning lathes, where a similar tool is used for parting.

Whatever the answer, my suggestion would be to avoid using a parting tool for parting off and keep it for sizing cuts on spindle work.

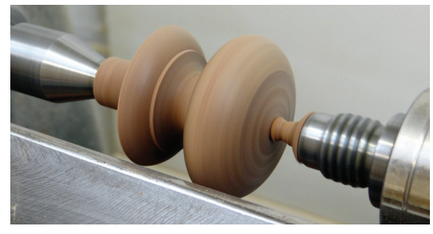


Using a parting tool across end grain results in a rough and torn surface

"If I had been using a skew chisel, I would continue to use this tool until the work was parted off"

My suggestion for parting is to continue to use whatever tool you have been using to cut the rest of the job. For this article I photographed the making of some sapele drawer pulls, which have a pleasant curve to their face, and need to stay that way once the waste is removed. I used a spindle gouge to cut the curved face and continued to use it for parting off. If I had been using a skew chisel, I would continue to use this tool until the work was parted off.

The reason for this is that the pressure applied to the wood with different tools will vary, which means there can often be a visual difference between the part cut with a gouge and a part cut with a skew, which will often be emphasised under a coat of finish. By sticking with the same tool throughout, you will immediately remove this potential issue.



Working partly with spindle gouge and partly with skew: note difference in surface colour and texture left by each tool

Leave a small nib

Waste area is taken down to a suitably thin section before final parting off

Parting without leaving a nib results in a patch of damaged end grain which is virtually impossible to remove

The temptation when parting off, is to try to maintain a curve right through, until the item is parted. The problem with attempting this is that the last few fibres of wood, connecting the work to the waste will almost always snap, rather than be cut, because of the forces involved in turning. This will result in damage to the end grain fibres, which can run surprisingly deep into the wood, being almost impossible to tidy up without reshaping the work and potentially spoiling it. The only answer is to cut the curve of the work as close to the centre as you dare, then part off leaving a tiny nib that will need removing at the end. This way, any end grain damage will be in this nib, rather than in your work, and is easily removable. How small you cut this nib will come with experience. The timber being used will be the main deciding factor. An open-grained timber such as oak (*Quercus robur*) or ash (*Fraxinus excelior*) will need a larger nib leaving than a tight-grained wood like maple (*Acer saccharum*). Softer woods will also require a larger leaving than on more dense timbers.

Removing the nib

The nib should be quite small, so removal should be pretty straightforward. There are two options that I regularly use.

The first is to carve it away using a sharp chisel, in much the same way that you would sharpen a pencil with a chisel. Hold the work below the level of the nib, keeping your hands away from the sharp edge of the chisel. Using a slicing cut and work with the grain, slicing and rotating the work alternately until all that is left is a small area of chiselled or carved surface. This can then be hand sanded and blended with the last abrasive grit that was used to finish the item.

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